

How the Epstein Files Became the Ultimate Conspiracy Theory

Michael Shermer examines the psychology behind pattern seeking, the limits of suspicion, and how the Epstein files fuel conspiracy thinking.

NICK GILLESPIE | 2.20.2026 11:45 AM



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How the Epstein Files Became the Ultimate Conspiracy

The Reason Interview With Nick Gillespie



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Today's guest is [Michael Shermer](#), founding publisher of [Skeptic magazine](#) and author of the new book [Truth: What It Is, How to Find It, and Why It Still Matters](#).

Shermer explains how the release of the Epstein files has fueled conspiracy thinking, particularly through guilt by association and pattern seeking. He explains why ambiguous evidence invites overinterpretation, how skepticism differs from cynicism, and why the demand for total certainty often leads people away from truth rather than toward it.

The conversation also explores the broader collapse of trust in institutions after COVID-19, the role of influencers in amplifying conspiratorial narratives, and why scientific and historical denialism have found new audiences online.

The Reason Interview With Nick Gillespie goes deep with the artists, entrepreneurs, and scholars who are making the world a more libertarian—or at least a more interesting—place by championing free minds and free markets.

0:00—Introduction

0:54—How Shermer appeared in the Epstein files

3:04—Epstein conspiracy theories

6:35—Minnesota ICE shootings

10:14—The difference between truth and objective facts

15:43—Do science and religion conflict?

22:55—The rise of science denialism

26:45—Government intervention in transgender medical treatment for minors

29:59—The importance of historical truths and the Holocaust

36:36—COVID-19 and the collapse of institutional trust

42:19—Defending liberal democracy

Producer: [Paul Alexander](#)

Audio Mixer: [Ian Keyser](#)

***NEXT:* Can Iran's Protest Movement Topple the Regime?**

NICK GILLESPIE is an editor at large at *Reason* and host of *The Reason Interview With Nick Gillespie*.

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